

Psalms 32

Blessed Forgiveness

Blessed is he whose transgression is forgiven
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Blessed is he whose transgression is forgiven, whose sin is covered.*
- 2 *Blessed is the man unto whom the LORD imputeth not iniquity, and in whose spirit there is no guile.*
- 3 *When I kept silence, my bones waxed old through my roaring all the day long.*
- 4 *For day and night thy hand was heavy upon me: my moisture is turned into the drought of summer. Selah.*
- 5 *I acknowledged my sin unto thee, and mine iniquity have I not hid. I said, I will confess my transgressions unto the LORD; and thou forgavest the iniquity of my sin. Selah.*
- 6 *For this shall every one that is godly pray unto thee in a time when thou mayest be found: surely in the floods of great waters they shall not come nigh unto him.*
- 7 *Thou art my hiding place; thou shalt preserve me from trouble; thou shalt compass me about with songs of deliverance. Selah.*
- 8 *I will instruct thee and teach thee in the way which thou shalt go: I will guide thee with mine eye.*
- 9 *Be ye not as the horse, or as the mule, which have no understanding: whose mouth must be held in with bit and bridle, lest they come near unto thee.*
- 10 *Many sorrows shall be to the wicked: but he that trusteth in the LORD, mercy shall compass him about.*
- 11 *Be glad in the LORD, and rejoice, ye righteous: and shout for joy, all ye that are upright in heart.*

2 · CONTEXT

Psalm 32 is the second of the traditional penitential psalms and reads as a companion to Psalm 51—not the moment of confession itself, but David’s testimony afterward, written to instruct others (“Maschil”) from his own experience. He traces the misery of holding sin in and the relief of letting it out, then widens into guidance and praise for all who trust the Lord. Paul cites verses 1–2 in Romans 4 as a picture of justification credited apart from works, making this psalm foundational to the doctrine of forgiveness by grace.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-2

The blessing is not sinlessness but forgiven transgression, covered sin, and a heart free of guile before God. This is the gospel in miniature centuries before the cross: blessing rests on the forgiven, not the flawless.

Verse 3-5

Silence about his sin wasted his body—roaring all day, bones failing under the weight of God’s hand—until he confessed: “I acknowledged my sin unto thee... and thou forgavest the iniquity of my sin.” Confession, not concealment, brought relief.

Verse 6-7

Therefore every godly person should pray while God may be found; He is a hiding place, preserves from trouble, and surrounds the trusting soul with “songs of deliverance.”

Verse 8-9

God promises to instruct and guide “in the way thou shalt go,” with a warning not to be like a stubborn horse or mule that must be forced by bit and bridle to move at all.

Verse 10-11

Many sorrows belong to the wicked, but mercy surrounds the one who trusts the Lord. The psalm ends where blessing began: be glad, rejoice, and shout for joy, all ye righteous.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Unconfessed sin quietly wastes a person from the inside; confession, not self-protective silence, is the doorway to real relief and instruction. Forgiveness is not the reward for having it together—it is the gift that lets a person be led rather than dragged.

Application for life today.

Notice what you are currently keeping silent before God out of fear or pride, and consider what it is costing your body and spirit. Practice verse 5's directness: name the specific sin rather than a vague sense of failure. Ask whether you are being led by God's eye (v. 8) or resisting like a mule that must be bridled into obedience.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no "right length" answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Is there a sin you have been carrying in silence that this psalm invites you to finally acknowledge to God?

2. How does Romans 4's use of verses 1–2 change how you think about being "blessed" before God?

3. Where might you be resisting God's guidance until it takes a "bit and bridle" to move you (v. 9)?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).